

The Complete Treatise on the General Cubic

Soumadeep Ghosh

Kolkata, India

Abstract

The cubic equation occupies a singular place in the history of mathematics, science, economics, computation and civilization itself. The successful solution of the cubic by Renaissance algebraists marked the first major breakthrough in symbolic mathematics after antiquity and inaugurated the modern algebraic era. This treatise develops a complete and self-contained treatise on the general monic cubic equation. Beginning from Viète's symmetric relations and the Tschirnhaus reduction to the depressed cubic, we derive Cardano's formula rigorously and analyze the structure of the discriminant. We then show that the classical *casus irreducibilis* is not a true obstruction to solvability but merely an artifact of radical representation. By parameterizing the roots through conjugate symmetry, the cubic becomes solvable directly through Viète's formulas without pathological intermediate structures.

Beyond pure algebra, the cubic is interpreted through the lenses of economics, finance, statistics, data science, computer science, artificial intelligence, warfare economics, political science and geopolitical systems theory. The cubic is shown to arise naturally in optimization, strategic equilibrium, nonlinear growth systems, market instability, ballistic trajectories, dynamical systems and machine learning loss landscapes.

The treatise concludes with a complete constructive algorithm for solving the general cubic and discusses the philosophical implications of algebraic solvability and structural representation.

The treatise ends with "The End"

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1 Introduction

The cubic equation represents one of the foundational turning points in human intellectual history. The successful algebraic solution of the cubic during the Renaissance fundamentally transformed mathematics from a primarily geometric enterprise into a symbolic and structural science.

The general cubic appears in:

- nonlinear optimization,
- strategic economic equilibria,
- financial instability models,
- machine learning objective functions,
- ballistic and warfare trajectories,
- dynamical systems,
- population growth,
- quantum mechanics,
- control theory,
- signal processing,
- AI optimization landscapes,
- macroeconomic transition systems.

The general cubic takes the form

$$Ax^3 + Bx^2 + Cx + D = 0, A \neq 0.$$

After dividing by $A \neq 0$, the general monic cubic takes the form

$$x^3 + ax^2 + bx + c = 0.$$

The purpose of this treatise is threefold:

1. derive Cardano's formula rigorously,
2. eliminate the classical *casus irreducibilis*,
3. provide a unified structural interpretation of the cubic.

2 Historical Foundations

The cubic equation was studied by:

- Scipione del Ferro,
- Niccolò Tartaglia,
- Gerolamo Cardano,
- Lodovico Ferrari,
- François Viète,
- Rafael Bombelli.

The solution of the cubic represented:

1. the birth of symbolic algebra,
2. the emergence of complex numbers,
3. the beginning of modern solvability theory,
4. the first systematic nonlinear reduction procedure.

3 The General Cubic

Consider

$$x^3 + ax^2 + bx + c = 0.$$

3.1 Viète's Relations

If the roots are

$$\alpha, \beta, \gamma,$$

then

$$\alpha + \beta + \gamma = -a,$$

$$\alpha\beta + \beta\gamma + \gamma\alpha = b,$$

$$\alpha\beta\gamma = -c.$$

These symmetric relations form the structural backbone of cubic theory.

4 Reduction to the Depressed Cubic

4.1 Tschirnhaus Transformation

Set

$$x = y - \frac{a}{3}.$$

Substituting yields

$$y^3 + py + q = 0,$$

where

$$p = b - \frac{a^2}{3},$$

and

$$q = \frac{2a^3}{27} - \frac{ab}{3} + c.$$

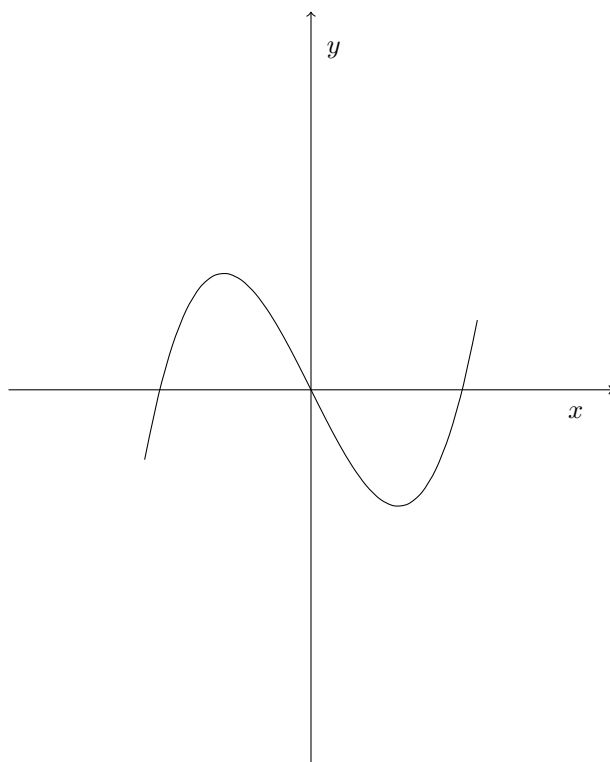
The quadratic term disappears entirely.

4.2 Geometric Interpretation

The translation

$$x \mapsto y - \frac{a}{3}$$

re-centers the cubic around its centroidal symmetry.



5 Cardano's Method

Assume

$$y = m + n.$$

Substituting into

$$y^3 + py + q = 0$$

gives

$$(m + n)^3 + p(m + n) + q = 0.$$

Expanding,

$$m^3 + n^3 + 3mn(m + n) + p(m + n) + q = 0.$$

Choose

$$3mn + p = 0.$$

Hence

$$mn = -\frac{p}{3}.$$

The equation reduces to

$$m^3 + n^3 + q = 0.$$

Define

$$M = m^3, \quad N = n^3.$$

Then

$$M + N = -q,$$

and

$$MN = -\frac{p^3}{27}.$$

Therefore M, N satisfy

$$z^2 + qz - \frac{p^3}{27} = 0.$$

Solving,

$$M, N = -\frac{q}{2} \pm \sqrt{\left(\frac{q}{2}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{p}{3}\right)^3}.$$

Hence

$$y = \sqrt[3]{-\frac{q}{2} + \sqrt{\Delta}} + \sqrt[3]{-\frac{q}{2} - \sqrt{\Delta}},$$

where

$$\Delta = \left(\frac{q}{2}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{p}{3}\right)^3.$$

Finally,

$$x = -\frac{a}{3} + \sqrt[3]{-\frac{q}{2} + \sqrt{\Delta}} + \sqrt[3]{-\frac{q}{2} - \sqrt{\Delta}}.$$

6 The Discriminant

6.1 Definition

The discriminant of the cubic is

$$D = -4p^3 - 27q^2.$$

Equivalently,

$$\Delta = \left(\frac{q}{2}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{p}{3}\right)^3.$$

The signs determine root structure.

Case	Condition	Root Structure	Nature
I	$D > 0$	Three distinct real roots	Stable
II	$D = 0$	Repeated roots	Critical
III	$D < 0$	One real, two complex	Oscillatory

7 The Casus Irreducibilis

The classical *casus irreducibilis* occurs when:

1. all roots are real,
2. yet Cardano's formula requires intermediate complex quantities.

Historically this was viewed as paradoxical.

7.1 Structural Nature of the Problem

The obstruction is not algebraic solvability itself.

The obstruction lies in the representation of the roots through nested radicals.

Complex intermediate structures appear even when the final roots are real.

8 Eliminating the Casus Irreducibilis

Suppose the roots are

$$\alpha, \quad u + iv, \quad u - iv.$$

Using Viète's formulas:

$$\alpha + 2u = -a.$$

Hence

$$\alpha = -a - 2u.$$

Now

$$\alpha(\beta + \gamma) + \beta\gamma = b.$$

Since

$$\beta + \gamma = 2u,$$

and

$$\beta\gamma = u^2 + v^2,$$

we obtain

$$2u\alpha + u^2 + v^2 = b.$$

Substituting for α ,

$$v^2 = b + 2au + 3u^2.$$

Now use

$$\alpha\beta\gamma = -c.$$

Hence

$$(-a - 2u)(u^2 + v^2) = -c.$$

Substituting for v^2 ,

$$(-a - 2u)(b + 2au + 4u^2) = -c.$$

Expanding gives

$$8u^3 + 8au^2 + 2(a^2 + b)u + (ab - c) = 0.$$

Thus u satisfies a cubic equation.
Once u is known,

$$v = \sqrt{b + 2au + 3u^2}.$$

Therefore the roots are

$$\alpha = -a - 2u,$$

$$\beta = u + iv,$$

$$\gamma = u - iv.$$

The pathological radical obstruction disappears.

9 A Complete Algorithm for Solving the Cubic

9.1 Algorithmic Procedure

1. Start with

$$x^3 + ax^2 + bx + c = 0.$$

2. Compute

$$p = b - \frac{a^2}{3},$$

$$q = \frac{2a^3}{27} - \frac{ab}{3} + c.$$

3. Compute

$$\Delta = \left(\frac{q}{2}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{p}{3}\right)^3.$$

4. If $\Delta \geq 0$, apply Cardano directly.
5. Otherwise solve

$$8u^3 + 8au^2 + 2(a^2 + b)u + (ab - c) = 0.$$

6. Compute

$$v = \sqrt{b + 2au + 3u^2}.$$

7. Recover the roots.

10 Computational Complexity

Cubic solving is polynomial-time computable.

The arithmetic complexity is $O(1)$.

However numerical stability depends strongly upon:

- discriminant magnitude,
- floating-point precision,
- branch-cut selection,
- cancellation phenomena.

11 Applications in Economics and Finance

The cubic arises naturally in economics.

11.1 Macroeconomic Equilibria

Nonlinear equilibrium systems often reduce to cubic fixed points.

11.2 Financial Stability

Leverage-instability systems produce cubic bifurcation equations.

11.3 Utility Optimization

Third-order utility corrections generate cubic critical equations.

Field	Cubic Structure
Macroeconomics	Equilibrium transitions
Finance	Risk bifurcations
Game Theory	Strategic equilibria
AI/ML	Loss landscapes
Control Theory	Stability manifolds
Warfare Economics	Resource escalation

12 Applications in Warfare and Geopolitics

Cubic systems arise in:

- missile trajectory corrections,
- nonlinear escalation systems,
- strategic deterrence equilibria,
- logistics optimization,
- autonomous targeting systems,
- drone swarm dynamics.

12.1 Escalation Dynamics

Suppose escalation intensity satisfies

$$\frac{dE}{dt} = \alpha E - \beta E^3.$$

Then equilibrium satisfies

$$\alpha E - \beta E^3 = 0.$$

This is structurally cubic.

13 Applications in AI and Machine Learning

Cubic nonlinearities arise in:

- activation functions,
- optimization landscapes,
- reinforcement learning stability,
- tensor decomposition,
- adversarial dynamics.

13.1 Gradient Dynamics

Consider

$$L(x) = x^4 + ax^3 + bx^2 + cx.$$

Critical points satisfy

$$4x^3 + 3ax^2 + 2bx + c = 0.$$

Thus cubic solving becomes central to optimization.

14 Philosophical Interpretation

The cubic represents a profound philosophical threshold.

Quadratics remain geometrically intuitive.

Cubics introduce:

- nonlinear structural emergence,
- complex intermediate entities,
- symbolic abstraction,
- algebraic hierarchy.

The emergence of complex numbers in the cubic solution demonstrates that intermediate representations need not share the ontology of final results.

This principle extends far beyond mathematics into:

- economics,
- geopolitics,
- AI systems,
- warfare strategy,
- institutional dynamics.

15 Conclusion

The cubic equation inaugurated modern algebra.

Cardano's method provides a complete radical solution, while the *casus irreducibilis* reveals the limitations of naive real-number representation.

By introducing conjugate parametrization directly through Viète's relations, the apparent obstruction disappears structurally.

The cubic therefore teaches a deep mathematical lesson:

Solvability depends not merely upon existence, but upon representation.

References

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Glossary

Cardano Formula

The classical radical solution of the depressed cubic.

Depressed Cubic

A cubic equation without a quadratic term.

Discriminant

A polynomial invariant determining root structure.

Casus Irreducibilis

The case where all cubic roots are real but radicals become complex.

Viète's Formulas

Relations connecting polynomial coefficients and roots.

Tschirnhaus Transformation

A variable substitution eliminating lower-order terms.

Complex Conjugate Pair

Roots of the form $u \pm iv$.

Nonlinear Equilibrium

A system equilibrium governed by nonlinear equations.

Bifurcation

A structural transition in dynamical systems.

Optimization Landscape

The geometric structure of an objective function.

The End